

eliminating the minorities. In Orissa, Christians and Muslims together constitute barely 4 per cent of the total population. The Congress's charge has been bolstered by the fact that the Patnaik Government has been partial towards the Hindutva forces. Not only firebrand VHP leader Pravin Togadia but two BJP MLAs Surama Padhi and Golak Nayak moved around freely during curfew hours and the police did nothing to stop them. Former chief minister and Leader of the Opposition J.B. Patnaik, says, "The Government deliberately neither protected the life of VHP leader Swami Lakshmanananda despite threats to his life nor did it protect the life and properties of the minority community."

The state, in the aftermath of the swami's killing, is witnessing a dangerous game. The body of the slain swami was taken out in procession before it was given samadhi at Chakpada

reservation. According to Pujari, these, along with unchecked, unlawful conversion, were the factors that caused anger among the Hindu tribals. CBCI spokesperson Father Babu Joseph points out: "It is indeed strange to mix up so many elements to bash the Church. Instead of blaming and targeting the Church, the Government should have taken legal action against those who violated land reforms or reservation laws."

Today, out of Kandhamal's total population of 6.48 lakh, 1,17,950 are Christians even though the state percentage of Christian population is just 1.87. However, while the Christian population's decadal growth was 38.7 in 1991 it declined by 4 per cent in 2001 mainly because of anti-conversion and reconversion campaigns. In 1967, Saraswati had reached Chakpada and started his crusade. He took a vow to stop conversions and vigorously opposed cow slaughter



TARGET: A tribal Christian widow with her sons and her burnt home

ashram set up by him. Soon, Hindutva forces were mobilised. The Shankaracharya of Puri and Gajapati Maharaj of Puri backed the VHP saying if sadhus and saints could not be protected then the Government had no business to remain in power. Then thousands of sadhus swarmed Bhubaneswar to protest the killing and condemn the Government's failure to arrest the killers.

There is a larger gameplan in the anti-Christian crusade. In Orissa, despite the minuscule presence of Christians, the Hindutva forces see a greater danger from them. In Kandhamal alone, while Scheduled Tribes constitute 51.96 per cent of the population, the scs represent 16.89 per cent. Yet the sc-Dalits, mostly Panas, are socially and economically powerful and enjoy the support of the Church. They have not only grabbed tribal lands but, with the backing of politicians, have manipulated the benefits of

and beef-eating. The current violence and communal divide have its roots in that history of conversions which started in 1850s.

With the state Government seemingly helpless and ineffective, the communal situation deteriorating and Hindutva mobilisation reaching a new high, a group of intellectuals, writers and artistes formed a 'core group' last week to plead to peace-loving Oriyas "to stop Orissa from becoming a Gujarat".

That plea is of little help to over 30,000 people sheltered in the relief camps in Kandhamal who continue to relive their nightmares. For them, another cycle of violence awaits as the Sangh Parivar, sensing a BJP victory in the next election, steps up its campaign to expand its base and force the Christians to fall in line through fear of retribution. What that means is more bloodshed. ■

IN COLD BLOOD

- The murder of VHP ideologue Swami Lakshmanananda Saraswati leads to destruction of churches, convents and houses in villages around Tikabali, Rakia, G-Udaygiri, Baliguda and Phulbani.
- At least 42 churches, over 250 dwellings and four convents have been destroyed while 18 people are killed. Around 30,000 are living in relief camps.
- The police have arrested 615 persons and registered 390 cases.